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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1965-1966

Coverage Date: 1965 AD - 1966 AD

## Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S): 1. Luguru Culture

The Luguru social system requires the presence of at least three separate clans. Not only does one have *lukolo* and *mtala*, one must also have a relationship known as *ugongo* (Swahili *utani*) with another clan. *Ugongo* is an institutionalized joking relationship between linked clans which are conceptualized as being the exact structural equivalents. One frequently marries a *mgongo*, who should at the same time be a cross-cousin. If she is not an actual cross-cousin, she is a classificatory one. Ideally, one should marry a father's sister's daughter, but a mother's brother's daughter is also thought of as being an excellent match. Where prolonged intermarriage has occurred, a person can be both MBD and FZD at the same time.

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I have shown elsewhere (BRAIN 1969) that marriage is ideally matrilocal, but that after 3–4 years, by which time a child should have been born and weaned, the 'delayed right of bride removal' occurs, and a man frequently takes his wife to the hamlet of his maternal uncle (who did the same in his generation). At the same time his mother may leave his father and join her son and brother on clan land. If one marries a matrilateral cross-cousin, of course, no move is necessary after the initial one to the wife's home. Marriage tends to be stable for about twenty years, after which the rate of divorce rises rapidly as mothers leave to live with their sons and brothers.

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The traditional belief system of the Luguru centered around a cult of the ancestral spirits, *mitsimu*, Swahili *mizimu* (see BRAIN 1973 and 1978). Rites for the spirits, *tambiko*, can only be performed with the assistance and participation of the joking partners from the linked clan, the *wagongo*, symbolically indicating the interdependence and complementarity of the two structurally equal and opposite groups. Not only do the *wagongo* play an essential role in the ancestral rites, their presence is also crucial when a death occurs. They wash and prepare the corpse, dig the grave and place the body in it, on the  373 left side if a woman, on the right if a man. They also carry out all the necessary household duties at this time. It is clear that their function is to preserve the ritual purity of the bereaved and to prevent them from being polluted by contact with death, which I have suggested elsewhere (BRAIN 1979) is the symbolic equivalent of incest. The possibility of incest and its connection to witchcraft is a constant source of anxiety (cf. BEIDELMAN 1966: 361).

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